

LPA1

Language Production, Theory and Acquisition

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

An ELL teacher with a well-stocked classroom library of 600 books is choosing a read-aloud for a newcomer who understands simple sentences about daily routines. The book fair is next month. Which choice best fits the input principle?

- A. Any book from the book fair, since exposure is what matters
- B. A grade-level chapter book, since more challenge means faster learning
- C. A book with only words the student already knows
- D. A picture book about a family's day with mostly familiar words and a few new ones supported by pictures

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A middle school ELL who scored well on a listening test refuses to speak when called on in front of 32 classmates. The class meets in a room with bright murals. What is the most likely explanation and response?

- A. The bright murals are distracting her; move her seat.
- B. Anxiety is raising her affective filter; start with partner or small-group talk before whole-class sharing.
- C. Keep calling on her in front of the class until she gets used to it.
- D. She has not understood the lessons; re-teach the listening content.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A teacher who recently earned a TESOL certificate wants intermediate ELLs to build speaking skills. The class uses tablets donated by a local business. Which activity best promotes negotiation of meaning?

- A. Listening to an audiobook on the tablets.
- B. Copying a model dialogue into notebooks.
- C. An information-gap task: each partner has half a map and they must talk to plan a route.
- D. A grammar worksheet on question forms.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

Across five writing samples, a learner who arrived in August always writes “He go to school” and never adds -s for third person. When a teacher points at one case, he cannot fix it. The samples were written in a green notebook. Is this an error or a mistake?

- A. A mistake; he was careless.
- B. An error; the third-person -s is not yet part of his system.
- C. A mistake, because he knows how to write sentences.
- D. Neither; any wrong form is simply a typo.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A learner usually says “She walks,” but once says “She walk.” When the teacher raises an eyebrow, she immediately says “She walks.” What is this?

- A. A mistake; the form is in her system.
- B. An error that needs explicit re-teaching.
- C. Fossilization of the form.
- D. Evidence she has not acquired the third-person -s.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

During a lively discussion about a field trip to a science museum, a student says, “Yesterday I bought a snack.” The teacher replies, “Oh, you bought a snack? What did you buy?” The trip cost \$12 per student. What type of feedback is this?

- A. Elicitation
- B. Explicit correction
- C. Metalinguistic feedback
- D. A recast

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher wants a student to produce the correct form of an irregular past-tense verb himself rather than hear it. Which response does that?

- A.** “No, say ‘bought,’ not ‘bued.’”
- B.** “Oh, you bought a snack.”
- C.** “Yesterday you ...?” with a pause for the student to finish
- D.** Ignore the error so he stays confident.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

In September a learner said “I went to the store.” In November, after starting in a new reading group of six, she says “I goed to the store” and “He runned fast.” Her parents asked about it at conferences. What does this most likely show?

- A.** The new reading group is teaching her wrong forms.
- B.** Regression: her English is getting worse.
- C.** A learning disability, since she used to be correct.
- D.** Development: she has learned the -ed rule and is overapplying it.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which learner sentence is the clearest example of overgeneralizing an English rule?

- A.** “I have two foots.”
- B.** “Yesterday I walk to school.”
- C.** “I no like apples.”
- D.** “The car red is fast.”

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A teacher with a new set of headphones for 20 learners notices several students say “sheep” for “ship.” The class meets before lunch. Which activity best targets this?

- A.** Reading long passages aloud for fluency.
- B.** Ignore it; pronunciation never affects meaning.
- C.** Minimal-pair work: students hear and sort ship/sheep, bit/beat, and then say them to a partner who points to the right picture.
- D.** Spelling tests on words with “ee” and “i.”

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which pair of words is a minimal pair in English?

- A.** their / there
- B.** pat / bat
- C.** ship / shape
- D.** cat / cats

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

Several Spanish-speaking students in a class that meets in a portable say “espeak” and “eschool.” Their teacher has a large collection of phonics cards. What is the best explanation?

- A.** Transfer from Spanish, which adds a vowel before an initial s-cluster.
- B.** A speech disorder that needs referral.
- C.** They are spelling the words wrong in their heads.
- D.** They need more phonics cards.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

An ELL teacher ~~with a well-stocked classroom library of 600 books~~ is choosing a read-aloud for a newcomer who understands simple sentences about daily routines. ~~The book fair is next month.~~ Which choice best fits the input principle?

Target word: level of input **Decides:** Input should be understandable but slightly beyond current level.

A	Camouflage	The source is irrelevant; the level decides.
B	Absolute language	Input far beyond the learner is not comprehensible.
C	Dropped element	Drops the “+1”; nothing new to acquire.
D	Correct	Mostly comprehensible with a small stretch.

2. Answer B Concept 2

A middle school ELL who scored well on a listening test refuses to speak when called on in front of 32 classmates. ~~The class meets in a room with bright murals.~~ What is the most likely explanation and response?

Target word: affective filter **Decides:** She understands (good listening score) but anxiety blocks speaking.

A	Camouflage	The room decor does not explain why she understands but will not speak.
B	Correct	Lowering anxiety lets understanding turn into production.
C	Absolute language	Forced public performance raises the filter further.
D	Inverted operation	Her listening score shows she understands.

3. Answer C Concept 3

A teacher ~~who recently earned a TESOL certificate~~ wants intermediate ELLs to build speaking skills. ~~The class uses tablets donated by a local business.~~ Which activity best promotes negotiation of meaning?

Target word: interaction task **Decides:** Partners must exchange missing information.

A	Dropped element	Input only; drops interaction and output.
B	Adjacent category	Writing practice with no real meaning to negotiate.
C	Correct	The gap forces clarifying, checking, and rephrasing.
D	Confusion set	Focuses on form without communication.

4. Answer B Concept 4

Across five writing samples, a learner ~~who arrived in August~~ always writes “He go to school” and never adds -s for third person. When a teacher points at one case, he cannot fix it. ~~The samples were written in a green notebook.~~ Is this an error or a mistake?

Target word: error vs. mistake **Decides:** Consistent and not self-correctable.

A	Confusion set	Mistakes are one-off slips a learner can fix.
B	Correct	It recurs and he cannot self-correct.
C	Adjacent category	General writing ability does not mean this form is acquired.
D	Absolute language	Consistent patterns reflect the learner’s system.

5. Answer A Concept 4 · transfer

A learner usually says “She walks,” but once says “She walk.” When the teacher raises an eyebrow, she immediately says “She walks.” What is this?

Target word: classify a self-corrected slip (reverse case) **Decides:** One-off and self-corrected.

A	Correct	She uses it correctly and self-corrects.
B	Inverted operation	Errors are consistent and not self-correctable.
C	Adjacent category	Fossilization is a long-term stuck error, not a single slip.
D	Confusion set	Her usual correct use shows she has.

6. Answer D Concept 5

During a lively discussion about a field trip to a science museum, a student says, “Yesterday I bought a snack.” The teacher replies, “Oh, you bought a snack? What did you buy?” ~~The trip cost \$12 per student.~~ What type of feedback is this?

Target word: feedback type **Decides:** The teacher reformulates the error correctly without comment.

A	Adjacent category	Elicitation prompts the student to produce the form.
B	Confusion set	Explicit correction states that something is wrong.
C	Inverted operation	That gives a rule hint, such as “past tense of buy is irregular.”
D	Correct	The teacher restates the utterance in correct form and continues the conversation.

7. Answer C Concept 5 · transfer

A teacher wants a student to produce the correct form of an irregular past-tense verb himself rather than hear it. Which response does that?

Target word: choose feedback by goal (reverse) **Decides:** The learner must self-correct.

A	Adjacent category	Explicit correction also gives the answer.
B	Confusion set	A recast supplies the form for him.
C	Correct	Elicitation pushes the learner to self-correct.
D	Dropped element	Drops feedback altogether.

8. Answer D Concept 6

In September a learner said “I went to the store.” In November, ~~after starting in a new reading group of six,~~ she says “I goed to the store” and “He runned fast.” ~~Her parents asked about it at conferences.~~ What does this most likely show?

Target word: interpret overgeneralization **Decides:** She is applying the regular -ed rule to irregular verbs.

A	Camouflage	The group change is irrelevant; the pattern is developmental.
B	Inverted operation	Reads a sign of growth as decline.
C	Absolute language	This U-shaped pattern is typical in acquisition.
D	Correct	Overgeneralization shows a new rule in her interlanguage.

9. Answer A Concept 6 · transfer

Which learner sentence is the clearest example of overgeneralizing an English rule?

Target word: identify overgeneralization (reverse) **Decides:** A regular rule applied to an irregular word.

A	Correct	Applies the regular plural -s to the irregular noun “foot.”
B	Dropped element	Leaves out a rule (past -ed) rather than overapplying it.
C	Confusion set	Reflects an early negation stage or first-language pattern, not an English rule overapplied.
D	Adjacent category	Word-order transfer from the first language.

10. Answer C Concept 7

A teacher ~~with a new set of headphones for 20 learners~~ notices several students say “sheep” for “ship.” ~~The class meets before lunch.~~ Which activity best targets this?

Target word: minimal-pair practice **Decides:** Two vowel sounds that change meaning in English.

A	Adjacent category	Fluency practice does not isolate the contrast.
B	Absolute language	Here the vowel change does change meaning.
C	Correct	Minimal pairs focus on the sound contrast that changes meaning.
D	Confusion set	Spelling is not the same as sound.

11. Answer B Concept 7 · transfer

Which pair of words is a minimal pair in English?

Target word: identify a minimal pair **Decides:** Words differing in exactly one sound, with different meanings.

A	Confusion set	Same sounds, different spelling: homophones.
B	Correct	Only /p/ vs. /b/ differs, and the meanings differ.
C	Dropped element	Different in more than one sound.
D	Adjacent category	The difference is an added morpheme, not a swapped sound.

12. Answer A Concept 8

Several Spanish-speaking students ~~in a class that meets in a portable~~ say “espeak” and “eschool.” ~~Their teacher has a large collection of phonics cards.~~ What is the best explanation?

Target word: L1 transfer in phonology **Decides:** Spanish words do not begin with s + consonant.

A	Correct	A predictable first-language sound pattern.
B	Absolute language	A shared, language-based pattern is not a disorder.
C	Confusion set	This is about sound structure, not spelling.
D	Camouflage	The card collection does not explain the pattern.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	5	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	4	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	9	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	4	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Comprehensible input	Acquisition grows from input learners mostly understand that is slightly beyond their current level (often written “i + 1”).	Assuming more exposure helps even when it is far over the learner’s head, or that input must be fully known.	Choosing the level of a text or talk for a learner.
2	The affective filter	Anxiety, low motivation, and low confidence act as a filter that blocks input from becoming acquisition.	Treating forced public performance as neutral practice.	A learner who understands but freezes or withdraws.
3	Interaction and negotiation of meaning	Learners acquire language when they must negotiate meaning with others (clarifying, checking, rephrasing) and push their own output.	Believing silent listening alone builds speaking skill.	Tasks with an information gap between partners.
4	Errors vs. mistakes	An error reflects the learner’s current system and recurs; a mistake is a one-time slip the learner can self-correct.	Treating every wrong form as carelessness.	A form that is wrong consistently versus once.
5	Types of corrective feedback	A recast reformulates the learner’s utterance correctly; elicitation prompts the learner to self-correct; explicit correction states the error; metalinguistic feedback gives a rule hint.	Confusing a recast with explicit correction.	A teacher’s reply to a learner’s error, and “which type is this?”
6	Interlanguage and overgeneralization	Learners build a rule-governed interlanguage; errors like “goed” or “childs” show a rule being overapplied and signal development.	Reading overgeneralization as backsliding or lack of learning.	A learner who used “went” earlier now says “goed.”
7	Phonemes and minimal pairs	Two sounds are separate phonemes in a language if swapping them changes meaning; minimal pairs (ship/sheep) test and teach this.	Treating any sound difference as a phoneme difference, or confusing spelling with sound.	Two words that differ in one sound.
8	Home-language transfer in pronunciation	Learners carry sound patterns from their first language into English, such as adding a vowel before initial s-clusters or devoicing final consonants.	Calling a transfer pattern a hearing or speech disorder.	A predictable pronunciation pattern shared by speakers of one language.

Course scope (public description): Language Production, Theory and Acquisition focuses on describing and understanding language and the development of language. It includes the study of acquisition theory, error correction strategies, and applied phonology.